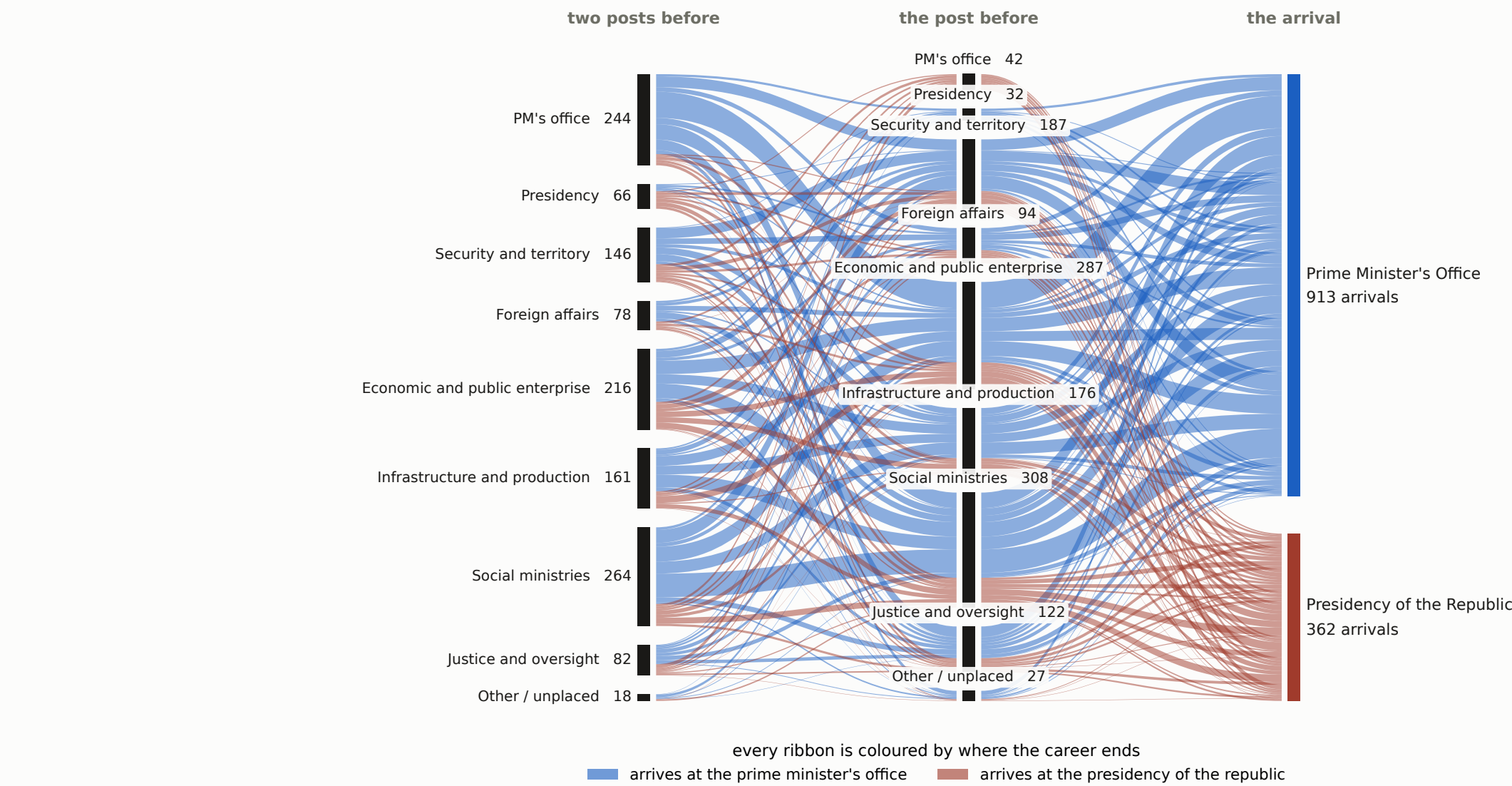


# The last two posts before the centre

All 1,275 three-step approaches to the two offices: the bloc a career was in two posts before arriving, the bloc it was in immediately before, and which office it reached. Each path holds one band through the middle column, so a ribbon can be followed across the whole diagram rather than only within a stage. Foreign affairs appears somewhere in the last two posts of 16% of approaches to the presidency against 12% of those to the prime minister's office, so the tilt the one-step figure found survives a step further back. The two offices are kept apart in every column, which shows what pooling them hid: where one is the post immediately before an arrival at the other, every one of those careers is a handover between them — 42 from the prime minister's office to the presidency and 32 the other way — while two posts back the centre is mostly returning to itself, 214 careers leaving the prime minister's office and coming back to it.



Source: Journal Officiel de la République Tunisienne, 1957–2026 (6,378 French issues, jort.tn). Author's extraction. An approach is a post in one of the two offices with two earlier posts in the same career, consecutive posts in one organisation collapsed so that what is counted is the crossing. Organisations are grouped into 9 blocs because at three steps the named routes are single figures — the commonest path into the presidency through two named predecessors is walked by nine people. The two offices are their own blocs in every column. An earlier draft pooled them, which made the middle column report a handover from one office to the other as though an office were staffing itself; no career can arrive at an office from that same office here, because consecutive posts in one organisation are collapsed before the sequence is read. With the centre split, the largest single bloc two posts before an arrival is social ministries at 264, not the centre. The diagram has a tail: 43 of its 125 left-hand ribbons carry fewer than five people and between them 8% of the flow. They are drawn so the column totals are honest, not to be read one by one. Three-step approaches are a subset of the arrivals in the one-step figure — 1,275 of 2,078 — because a career must have two earlier posts in the record to appear here at all, and which careers do is itself uneven across the period.